Statement on the April 2026 Committee Elections

Date: *8th May, 2026*

Executive summary

Intersect ran committee elections in April 2026 across eight committees. As part of routine post-election review, our auditing identified an unusual concentration of voting activity that warranted closer examination. We commissioned an independent third party audit alongside our internal analysis. Both reached consistent conclusions.

This statement sets out findings, and the decisions taken to preserve the integrity of the announced results, the path available to affected members, and how we intend to continue developing our membership and election processes. It is intended to be candid about what we observed while being careful not to attribute intent or wrongdoing to any individual on the basis of statistical patterns alone.

Observations

At least 4 patterns combined to produce the signal that triggered our review.

1. Concentration of memberships across a small number of payment cards

Of the 347 voters in the 2026 cycle, 162 (46.7%) were linked to memberships paid through only three payment cards. Across the same three cards, a total of 190 memberships had been purchased.

Card	Memberships paid for	Of which voted	Share of voters (347)
Card 1	110	87	25.1%
Card 2	55	52	15.0%
Card 3	25	23	6.6%
Total (3 cards)	**190**	**162**	**46.7%**

2. Tightly correlated voting concentrated on a small group of candidates

Votes from accounts linked to those three cards were not spread evenly across the candidate field. They concentrated on a small group of candidates. An independent Jaccard-based blocking analysis, conducted by Dquandrant, confirmed that the level of correlation observed sits well outside the range expected from independent voter choice. In several committees, removing cluster-linked votes from the count moves multiple candidates from leading positions to the lower end of their results.

Candidate	Committee	Original	From cluster	Recalculated
Candidate A	Budget	171	155	16
Candidate A	Civics	169	156	13
Candidate B	Budget	161	150	11
Candidate C	Growth & Marketing	169	153	16
Candidate D	Growth & Marketing	167	150	17
Candidate E	Membership & Community	162	152	10
Candidate F	Membership & Community	158	147	11
Candidate G	Membership & Community	143	135	8
Candidate H	Intersect Steering	175	152	23
Candidate I	Product	167	151	16

How to read this table. *“Original” is the raw vote count. “From cluster” is the share of those votes traced to the three-card cluster. “Recalculated” is what remains once cluster-linked votes are excluded*

3. Correlation between card owners and voted candidates

The three individuals whose payment cards funded over 190 memberships are themselves named candidates in the April 2026 committee elections, and each received a large share of votes from accounts within their own card cluster. In other words, the accounts paid for by these three individuals voted in significant numbers for those same individuals, and for a small group of candidates closely associated with them. The connection between who funded the memberships, which accounts cast votes, and which candidates received those votes is direct and traceable in the data.

4. A spike in membership purchases in the days immediately before voting

Membership purchases over the period leading up to the election show a sharp departure from the established baseline. The independent third party audit found that, against a long-term baseline of one to five new memberships per day, 50 to 60 new memberships were created on each of 6, 8, 12 and 15 April, in the days immediately preceding the voting deadline. The timing aligns closely with the period during which the cluster of accounts described in the previous sections came into existence.

Summary from third-party analysis

The third party auditor examined 6,253 votes cast by 347 distinct members across 8 committee races, scoring 102 candidates in total. Almost every vote satisfies the formal eligibility rule. The structural anomalies, however, are pronounced and concentrated:

- 12 of the 102 candidates drew >70% of their support from accounts whose first paid membership is less than 90 days old. Several drew 95–98%.
- 10 voter blocs were detected - groups of voters whose ballots are at least 95% identical. 8 of those blocs (covering ~83 voters) cast the bulk of their votes for the 12 flagged candidates (between 69% and 100% of each bloc's votes go to flagged candidates).
- 126 individual voters score ≥50/100 on a sybil-fingerprint check (templated username, no profile content, only voter-tier badges, voted within days of signing up). The mean score for bloc voters is 40/100, vs 26/100 for everyone else.

- A dramatic spike in membership purchases appears in the days immediately preceding the deadline which highlights 50–60 new memberships per day on Apr 6, 8, 12, 15, vs the long-term baseline of 1–5 per day.
- The 12 brigaded candidates include the top vote-getter in 6 of the 8 committees on raw counts.

These patterns individually pass the per-vote rule. Collectively they describe a coordinated voting effort using accounts created shortly before the election.

The full third party analysis can be reviewed here.

Extra context that we have taken into consideration

We understand that at times the same individual might own multiple memberships (for example, an enterprise membership alongside an individual membership), and that on its own this is not evidence of misconduct. We want to be clear about that.

We also understand that members of the Cardano community live in many countries, and that access to USD or ada varies between regions. Where local banking rails, exchange access, or payment infrastructure are constrained, it is common and entirely legitimate for community organisers, family members, employers, sponsors, or local groups to pay membership dues on behalf of others. We recognise that more can and should be done to make participation in Intersect easier and more accessible for members in those regions, and we are committed to continuing that work.

What we cannot compromise on, however, is the principle at the heart of the Membership Agreement: that membership is personal to the member who signs it, and is non-transferable and non-assignable. The right to vote attaches to the individual member who joined, agreed to the terms, and engages with the work of Intersect. When that principle holds, a payment made on someone's behalf is simply a payment, and the member continues to contribute and participate. When it does not, the link between membership, identity and voice breaks, and one-member-one-vote ceases to mean what it says.

Decisions taken

We must be able to confidently establish that each vote is cast by the individual member. Where that confidence is not present, it introduces ambiguity that undermines the principle of one-member-one-vote.

What distinguishes the present case from ordinary multi-account use is the combination of factors observed at scale, which together indicated that this principle had not been respected:

- The number of memberships funded through a small number of payment cards
- The very recent date on which most of these memberships were created
- The unusually tight alignment of votes from those accounts
- The alignment of those votes with candidates operationally connected to the cluster, including through coordinated support during the account verification process

Considered together, these factors crossed the threshold at which we judged that announcing the unadjusted tallies would not faithfully represent the independent preference of the membership.

Therefore, the decision and follow-up action taken by Intersect Leadership, in agreement with the Board, has been to invalidate the votes from the identified coordinated cluster. The recalculated tallies form the basis of the announced results.

Interim actions taken

In addition to the decision taken above, and to draw a line under the April 2026 committee elections and protect the integrity of the announced results, the executive team, under the agreement of the Board, has taken the following interim actions:

- Membership rights, including voting rights, for the accounts purchased through those three cards have been suspended on an interim basis, pending individual review. The personal memberships of the three card owners themselves are subject to the same review process.
- A dedicated support channel has been established for any affected members as part of the temporary suspension and review process.
- All evidence relating to the review, including voter exports, payment records, account verification logs, and audit working papers, has been preserved.

These are protective and time-bound steps. They are taken to close the 2026 election cycle on a sound footing and to allow each affected case to be reviewed properly.

Long-term suspension or expulsion

Any longer-term action affecting a member's standing sits with the Board, not the executive team. Article 2.8 of our Bylaws provides that suspension or expulsion of a member for cause may be taken by the Board, after an appropriate hearing and at least 15 days' written notice, and requires action by the Board itself, by a two-thirds vote of Directors.

Following the individual review process described below, any cases where definitive action is considered appropriate will be put to the Board for decision under that procedure. Affected members will have the opportunity to be heard before any such decision is taken.

Path forward for affected members

During this temporary suspension, each affected member has been notified by email and is invited to provide context, supporting information, and any explanation they consider relevant. Each case will be reviewed individually and on its own merits. If further action is required, the Board will be notified in accordance with our Bylaws.

Members who wish to engage with the review can write to membership@intersectmbo.org.

Our governing framework and system architecture

The principles by which Intersect members join, participate and vote are set out in our publicly available governing documents: the Bylaws, the Membership Governance document, and the Membership Agreement.

The action we have taken in response to the April 2026 committee elections is grounded in those documents. The patterns described in this statement were identifiable as a material concern, and the response is calibrated to be proportionate, precisely because the framework has been in place and is working as intended. The system design and architecture continue to support the integrity of the membership and the elections it underpins.

In closing

With the actions described above, the 2026 committee elections are now closed. The recalculated results reflect, to the best of our ability, the genuine preference of independent members. We thank the candidates who stood, the members who participated, and the auditors and analysts whose work supported this review.

A continuous cycle of improvements and efficiencies will continue, as it has done since our first elections, through collaboration and consultation between Intersect staff, our committees, and the Board.

Approved and endorsed by the Intersect MBO Board of Directors